

4: Meaning

What is “Meaning” and why is it so important to Sociology?

Look at this illustration.¹ What do you see?

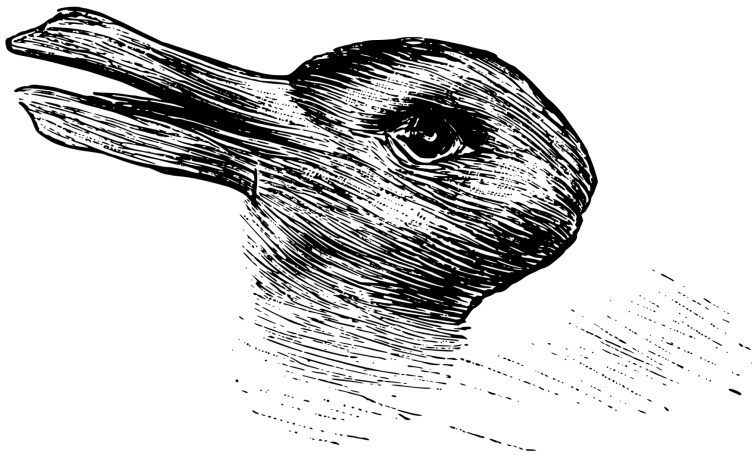


Figure 1: An Optical Illusion

¹ This illusion is the famous “rabbit and duck” illustration, originally [from](#) an 1884 German Newspaper, which is commonly used to demonstrate the “gestalt shift” in psychology by which the illustration’s appearance suddenly shifts from “being” a rabbit to “being” a duck.

Some people see a rabbit. Some see a duck. Some see something in between. But what matters for us here is not exactly *what* you saw, but *that* you saw something in the first place. Someone, inspired perhaps by a rabbit or a duck, made an illustration with a pen and their hand, then that was scanned digitally and it now *is* only an arrangement of pixels on your screen. But your brain was able to take that arrangement of pixels and integrate it into a symbol representing something

else, namely, a rabbit (or duck, or something in between). Sociologists (and other social scientists and humanities scholars) summarize this action of your brain to integrate stimuli into references to something else out ability to perceive **meaning** or **significance** in the world.

Sociologists care so much about meaning for a few reasons, but the most central relates to social constructions. Recall that social constructions are just real phenomena in the world which exist by virtue of our shared acceptance that they exist. That word *shared* is the key: for *how can it be* that we manage to arrive at the same, or even just similar, collective (or at least intersubjective) understandings of what is happening? A theory of meaning provides the answer—it is the ability to arrive at a shared understanding of what a thing, social setting, or phenomenon is “about,” at least enough so to enable communication.

As we discussed in the [last unit](#), when discussing Symbolic Interactionism, the meanings we find in symbols have a general structure: that of a **symbol**. A symbol is composed of two parts: the **signifier**, which is the thing that is doing the representing, and the **signified**, which is the meaning or significance being represented. Sometimes, the relationship between signifier and signified is *iconic*, which is to say, one of direct resemblance. This is most famous in some languages, like [ancient Egyptian hieroglyphics](#). But there are also times where meaning is highly dependent on its contextual appearance among other symbols. Most modern languages follow this more complex pattern.

Sociologists tend to study these complex objects, symbols, and their meaning at two levels of analysis, the micro and macro.

Micro-Analysis of Culture

At the micro level, going back to the beginning of the sociological tradition (this time to a sociologist named Max Weber, who also theorized “rationalization”), sociologists have seen a tight coupling of meaning and action together. Indeed, Weber saw them as identical: for a person to “act” (which is to say, do something), was for them to

[attach] subjective meaning to his behavior—be it overt or covert, omission or acquiescence. Action is ‘social’ insofar as its subjective meaning takes account of the behavior of others and is thereby oriented in its course...in no case does [meaning] refer to an objectively ‘correct’ meaning or one which is ‘true’ in some metaphysical sense (Weber 1978:4).

Weber, Max. 1978. *Economy and Society*. Berkeley: University of California.

Start with Weber's basic sociological terms.

How do meanings motivate and justify action for people and groups?

Macro-Analysis of Culture

Starts with Durkheim's views from the duality of human nature.

Asks how meanings are structured in relationship to one another, and how they mutate and change over time in complex societies.

Study the overall social function of some meanings vs others and their sociostructural outcomes.

The composition of meaning into symbols, made of signifier and signified. In simple cases, what is signified is a concrete, material entity in the world. In a great number of other cases, however, what is signified by a symbol is **not** concrete, as in the concepts of a "market" or "love."

Meaning as unifying

it is difficult to overstate the importance of culture and meaning to the conduct of your everyday life. It is there that all information is stored that literally keeps you alive, and allows you to interact with society.